JUNE 26, KISHANGANJ

A portion of the 70-metre-long, 12-metre-wide bridge, built in 2011 under the Mukhyamantri Gram Sadak Yojana, gives way. The bridge over the Mariya river connects the Bahadurganj and Dighalbank blocks

Cost: Rs 25 lakh

Reason: Heavy rains in Nepal's catchment areas cause a sudden rise in water levels, a pillar fails to withstand the strong currents

JUNE 23, EAST CHAMPARAN

A span of a 16-metre-long under-construction bridge, built over a canal by the rural works department in the Ghorasahan block in Motihari, crumbles

Cost: Rs 1.6 crore

Reason: Unknown miscreants are alleged to have damaged the structure

JUNE 22, SIWAN

Part of a 100-metre-long, 40-year-old bridge over a canal in Ramgarha panchayat of Daraundha block falls down at one end

Cost: Rs 10 lakh

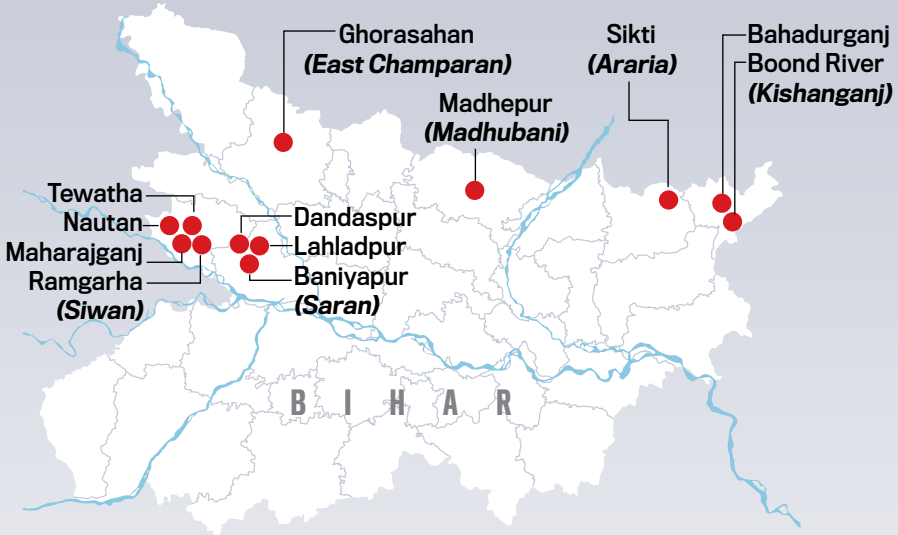
Reason: The brick wall and pillars connecting the bridge to the approach road weakened after the canal was dredged for desilting

JUNE 18, ARARIA

A major portion of a reinforced cement concrete bridge over the Bakra river in Sikti block collapses. The bridge was being rebuilt under the PM Gramin Sadak Yojana after a change in the river's course

Cost: Rs 12 crore

Reason: Excavation to allow the smooth flow of water is said to have weakened the pillars



WHY THEY CRUMBLE SO OFTEN

- Structural failures, often due to **alterations in the design and use of sub-standard materials**– low-strength cement, sand, concrete and steel rods etc.
- In many cases, those in charge of construction **violate norms and those tasked with monitoring collude** to ignore the lapses
- **Desilting and dredging operations** carried out to prepare for the monsoon at times compromise the stability of the foundations

*Reasons have been provided by government officials and engineers; all costs are estimated and are in reference to the time of construction

WHAT THE STATE HAS DONE



On July 5, the Bihar government suspended 15 engineers from the water resources and rural works departments for alleged negligence. It introduced a bridge maintenance policy designed to guide engineers in the maintenance, construction and repair of bridges



The new policy mandates that departments such as road construction, water resources and building construction issue "health cards" with detailed records of inspection and maintenance. This requirement also applies to bridges constructed with MPLAD and MLALAD funds



The policy stipulates two routine inspections per year, one of which must occur before the monsoon. If any desilting exercises are planned, the bridge must be inspected under the supervision of experts and a senior engineer from the relevant department



Additionally, each department will be allocated a dedicated fund for the maintenance of its bridges

